

The Bible the Apostles Carried

The first churches read their Scriptures in Greek translation, and the New Testament quotes it on nearly every page. Knowing that should steady you, not shake you.

ORIGINS

How Israel's Scriptures Learned Greek

By the third century BC, more Jews lived outside the land than in it, and most of them spoke Greek, not Hebrew. Their children were losing the language of Moses. So in Alexandria, the great Greek city of Egypt, Jewish scholars translated the Torah into Greek, and over the following century and beyond, the prophets and the writings followed.

A later legend, told in the Letter of Aristeas, credited the work to seventy-two translators, which is why the translation is called the Septuagint, from the Latin for seventy, abbreviated LXX. The legend grew in the telling. The translation itself was real, and it became the Bible of the Greek-speaking Jewish world, read every Sabbath in the synagogues of Alexandria, Antioch, Asia Minor, and Rome.

Which means it became the Bible of the early church. When the apostles carried the gospel out of Judea, they did not first have to translate the Scriptures for the nations. God had seen to that two centuries before Bethlehem. The Word was already waiting in the language of the streets.

THE DIFFERENCES

Why the Quotation Does Not Match Your Old Testament

Every careful reader eventually notices it. You follow a New Testament quotation back to your Old Testament and the words do not quite match. Hebrews 10 quotes Psalm 40 as saying a body you have prepared for me, but your Psalm 40 says my ears you have opened. Matthew hears Isaiah 7 promising that the virgin shall conceive, where your Isaiah may read young woman.

The explanation is not sloppiness. The New Testament writers were usually quoting the Septuagint, the version their readers knew, the way a preacher today quotes the translation in the pews. Sometimes the Greek translators rendered a Hebrew idiom interpretively. Sometimes, as the Dead Sea Scrolls have shown, they were translating a Hebrew text that differed slightly from the one later standardized. The Scrolls contain Hebrew manuscripts that agree with the Septuagint against the medieval Hebrew text in a

number of places.

So the differences you notice are not cracks in the foundation. They are the visible grain of a long, careful, human process that God did not bypass. He worked through it. He always has.

THE SHELF

What the Scriptures Meant in the First Century

When Jesus says the Scriptures testify about him, what shelf is he pointing to? The risen Lord names it in Luke 24. The Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms, the threefold shape Jewish tradition still uses. The core was firm and universally received. Torah, the prophets, the psalms. The outer edges were still being discussed, and a few books were debated for generations.

Greek-speaking communities also read and treasured books composed or preserved in Greek, the books later called deuterocanonical, like Maccabees and Wisdom of Solomon. That history, not some modern conspiracy, is why Catholic and Protestant Old Testaments differ in length today.

And remember what a Bible physically was. Not a bound volume on a nightstand but a cabinet of scrolls, expensive and communal, kept at the synagogue. Scripture was heard far more than it was read, and memorized to a degree that shames us. When Jesus says it is written, he is appealing to words his hearers carry inside them. The first century did not own Bibles. It knew them.

THE TRADITIONS

Oral Torah and the Living Conversation

Scripture in the first century never traveled alone. It came wrapped in interpretation. The Pharisees cultivated what they called the tradition of the elders, an oral Torah applying the written commands to daily life, the tradition Jesus engages in Mark 7. In the synagogues of the land, the Hebrew reading was followed by an Aramaic paraphrase, the targum, which often explained as it translated. Teachers debated texts by linking verse to verse, the method later collected in the midrash.

The New Testament was written inside that conversation, and it argues like a participant. Jesus proves the resurrection from the tense of a verb in Exodus 3, exactly the kind of close reading his contemporaries practiced. Paul, trained under Gamaliel, chains quotations the way the schools did. The early church did not invent reading Scripture about the Messiah. It inherited a culture that read Scripture toward the future, and it announced that the future had arrived.

None of this flattens the Bible into its background. It means the Bible spoke a living language to living readers. It still expects to.

THE POINT

Confidence, Not Anxiety

Some believers hear all this and feel the floor tilt. Translations, variant texts, debated edges, oral traditions. If that is the history, what exactly am I holding? Breathe. Then look at what the history actually shows.

It shows a God who was content to give his word in translation from the beginning, whose apostles called a Greek version Scripture without embarrassment. It shows transmission careful enough that the Isaiah scroll found at Qumran, a thousand years older than our previous Hebrew copies, reads recognizably as the Isaiah in your lap. It shows that the variety we can now see is the same variety the first Christians read, preached, and died trusting. Nothing has been discovered that they were protected from. The faith was born with its eyes open.

And it leaves us without one favorite excuse. The apostles had no leather-bound certainty, no single perfect edition, and they turned the world over with what they had. We have more access to the text than any generation in history and often less appetite for it. The question was never whether the Scriptures can bear our weight. It is whether we will finally put our weight down.

KEY TEXTS

Luke 24:44-45

Matthew 1:22-23

Hebrews 10:5-7

SOURCES

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